

Bryan Nelson

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WORK EXPERIENCE

Harvard Graduate School of Education, Cambridge, MA

Senior Project Coordinator, Ecological Approaches to Social and Emotional Learning Lab

March 2023 – Present

- Coordinate the expansion of the PSS-SEL Toolbox (inee.exploresel.gse.harvard.edu) through global stakeholder engagement to link social and emotional learning (SEL) frameworks, practices, and measurement tools.
- Manage data across multiple projects at various stages including data collection, cleaning, analysis and presentation in papers, conference proceedings, and project websites.
- Oversee the development and maintenance of the SEL Kernels website (selkernels.gse.harvard.edu) for the national rollout of SEL Kernels in Ukraine, providing resources to 140,000 teachers.
- Facilitate trainings on social and emotional activities for school-aged children globally, including the United States, Chile, Uganda, and Ukraine, using both a direct training model and train-the-trainer model.
- Collaborate with local stakeholders to contextualize and localize social and emotional activities designed for in-school and out-of-school settings in Chile and Uganda.
- Developed quantitative data reports to track project progress and outcomes both during implementation and post-project completion, facilitating informed decision-making on project design and implementation.

Project Coordinator, Ecological Approaches to Social and Emotional Learning Lab

December 2019 – March 2023

- Managed the development of the PSS-SEL Toolbox (inee.exploresel.gse.harvard.edu), a set of online tools for supporting psychosocial support (PSS) and social emotional learning (SEL) in global settings, using iterative development that relied on feedback from reference groups, surveys, focus groups, and field testing resulting in an online resource accessed by nearly 8,000 users in the first three years.
- Led and contributed to international workshops designed to identify local social and emotional needs and to prioritize skills locally and nationally, in countries such as Lebanon, India, and South Africa.
- Led a development iteration to improve the accessibility of the Explore SEL website to meet Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.0.

Research Assistant, Ecological Approaches to Social and Emotional Learning Lab

May 2015 – December 2019

- Oversaw the development of Explore SEL (exploresel.gse.harvard.edu), a website designed to organize, describe, and connect SEL frameworks and skills, and used by 74,000 users in the first two years.
- Designed surveys, cleaned data, analyzed results, and internally presented on the development of SEL skills of pre-K through 8th grade students, across four sites over four years.
- Developed a coding system and process designed to align SEL frameworks, standards, and measurements, and trained coders on process and software required to perform the coding.
- Generated reports to summarize research findings and provide recommendations to school administrators, funders, external research teams, and the public.

Teaching Fellow (Graduate-level)

Introduction to Educational Neuroscience; Beyond Grit: Noncognitive Factors in School Success

Fall 2014, Spring 2016

- Facilitated weekly group discussions to build further understanding of core readings in educational neuroscience.
- Provided feedback on course project through email and office hours, and graded the final project, a 12-18 page paper exploring the relationship between education and neuroscience.
- Participated in weekly teaching team meetings to update course design and section requirements.

Harvard University, Cambridge, MA

Project Manager, Office of Faculty Development and Diversity

January 2012 – May 2014

- Coordinated with Faculty Affairs Offices at various schools within Harvard to implement a university-wide faculty hiring and promotions system through a third-party software vendor, while maintaining a consistent university-wide policy.
- Generated the Faculty Development and Diversity Annual Report, tracking longitudinal faculty trends and peer comparisons in growth and diversity.
- Created ad hoc faculty reports for events lists and presentations aimed at internal and external audiences.

EF Education First, Cambridge, MA

Systems Analyst, Smithsonian Student Travel

January 2011 – December 2011

- Oversaw enhancements of in-house software by defining project scope and performing end user testing, as the subject matter expert for business needs.
- Prioritized new projects and bug fixes in coordination with four other products within the company, to ensure that system development maximizes the potential of staff.
- Developed new reports and run existing reports as requested by Sales and Operations departments.

Business Analyst, Tours Business Solutions

June 2010 – January 2011

- Managed simultaneous projects, in coordination with developers, stakeholders and business analysts.
- Represented business needs in the IT department through the creation, organization, and execution of user test cases.
- Led an iteration of business intelligence, a high-level project with product presidents as the primary stakeholders.

Program Specialist, Smithsonian Student Travel

June 2008 – June 2010

- Prevented problems by proactively communicating with over 50 colleagues and serving as communications hub between Sales and Operations.
- Trained new staff hires on the production process and led semi-annual trainings for all staff.
- Ensured quality control for Sales and Customer Service by generating and following up on daily, weekly and monthly reports related to tour production.

Tour Consultant, Smithsonian Student Travel

August 2007 – June 2008

EDUCATION

Master of Education, Mind, Brain, and Education
Harvard Graduate School of Education, Cambridge, MA, 2014-2015

Bachelor of Arts, History, Greek and Roman Civilization
University of Notre Dame, B.A., Notre Dame, IN, 2003-2007

John Cabot University, Rome, Italy, 2005
University of Notre Dame Study Abroad Program

SKILLS AND APPLICATIONS

Skills: Project Management, Training, Quantitative and Qualitative Research, Data Cleaning, Data Analysis, Data Reporting, Survey Design, Business Analysis, QA Testing

Applications: Microsoft Office, R, Qualtrics, ATLAS.ti, Stata

LEADERSHIP ROLES

Upstone Montessori School, Nashua, NH

Secretary

2025 - Present

President-Elect, Board of Directors

2020 - 2025

Upstone Montessori School provides full-day classrooms for three-, four-, and five-year-old children—encompassing two years of preschool and kindergarten—in a mixed-age environment.

Living Root Dragon Boat, Boston, MA

Coach, Vice President

2009-2016

Living Root is a competitive Boston-based dragon boat team.

SELECT PUBLICATIONS AND PRESENTATIONS

Bailey, R., Stolz, E., Temko, S., Gura, T., Roma, O., **Nelson, B.**, Rubin, C., Jones, S.M. (2026) Adapting and Scaling During a Crisis: A National Rollout of SEL Kernels in Ukraine. *Social and Emotional Learning: Research, Practice, and Policy*. doi:<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.sel.2026.100189>

Nelson, B., Mbau, E. (2026, March 28). *The PSS-SEL Toolbox: A process for providing accessible and contextually adaptable PSS-SEL tools*. [Panel presentation]. Comparative & International Education Society 2026 Conference, San Francisco, CA, United States.

Nelson, B., Bailey, R., Jones, S.M. (2025, October 8). *Using practical data from teachers to explore patterns in children's social and emotional development*. [Panel presentation]. Society for Study of Human Development Biennial Conference, Lexington, KY, United States.

Temko, S., Smith, R., **Nelson, B.**, Park, C., Bailey, R., Finder Johna, J., Diazgranados Ferráns, S., and Jones, S.M, Responding to the Field: Development of and Findings from the PSS-SEL Toolbox. *Social and Emotional Learning: Research, Practice, and Policy*, (2023) doi:<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.sel.2023.100017>

Nelson, B., Jones, S.M., Bailey, R. (2023, April 13). *Frameworks for Social and Emotional Learning From Across the Globe: Comparing, Contrasting, and Localizing* [Panel presentation]. AERA Annual Meeting.

Brush K.E., Jones S.M., Bailey R., **Nelson B.**, Raisch N., Meland E. (2021). Social and Emotional Learning: From Conceptualization to Practical Application in a Global Context. In: DeJaeghere J., Murphy-Graham E. (eds) *Life Skills Education for Youth. Young People and Learning Processes in School and Everyday Life*, vol 5. Springer, Cham. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-85214-6_3

Nelson, B., Temko, S., Bailey, R., Jones, S.M. (2020, April 16). *Mapping social emotional learning and related skills across frameworks used by the Lebanon Ministry of Education* [Panel presentation]. Comparative & International Education Society 2020 Conference.

Nelson, B., Bailey, R., Brush, K., Jones, S.M. (2019, March 21-23). *Looking Inside and Across SEL Frameworks: Findings from a Preliminary Analysis of the Taxonomy Project* [Paper presentation]. Society for Research in Child Development Biennial Conference, Baltimore, MD.